then the world's largest political party, was over double the size of the BJP at 87.79 million.[11] The maximum RSS daily shakha strength in 2014—an estimated 4.49 million active members—was about one-seventh of the BJP's members. (The RSS does not officially report its primary membership, but annually reports its daily, weekly and monthly shakhas and training camp numbers. For our purposes here, I have made an informed estimate of active RSS members from these reports. First, I discounted the monthly and weekly shakhas—assuming that some people who go to daily shakhas may also be going to the weekly and monthly ones. Then, I used the RSS's officially reported number of daily shakhas in a year to make three projections: based on whether the average number of attendees at each shakha was fifteen, fifty or one hundred. The calculation gave us an approximate minimum and maximum range for RSS membership numbers. In our comparison of the RSS, the BJP and the CCP, we used the upper range: one hundred attendees on average per RSS shakha. This gave us an estimated maximum of 4.49 million RSS members in 2014.)[12] In other words, to the BJP's 35 million members in 2014, the RSS had a maximum of 4.49 million.

The BJP tripled in size between 2014 and 2015, the year it surpassed the CCP.[13] Its reported strength of 110 million primary members in 2015 positively dwarfed the CCP's 88.76 million that year. By then, the party was also roughly twenty times the size of the RSS. By 2019, it had expanded to 174 million signed-up members. This was about twenty-nine times the estimated size of the RSS (see Figure 8.1).

Figure 8.1: Membership Patterns of BJP, Chinese Communist Party and RSS